

Melissomelos

Bees' melody, commonly called the 'Bee madrigal'

Charles Butler (d. 1647)

Complete edition by Magnus Williamson for the *Bee-ing Human* project (Leverhulme Trust, 2022-25). First performed complete by Ensemble Pro Victoria, Newcastle University, 29 February 2024.

Melissomelos

(the so-called 'Bee madrigal')

Charles Butler

STC 4193, sigs. L1-2

Meane Contratenor

Tenor Bassus

1

1. As of all states the Mo - nar - chie is best,
 2. They work in com - mon for the com - mon weale:

3. When so in - creased is this pru - dent na - tion
 4. To whose grave ac - cents if hir Prince - ly Grace

4

om 1634

So of all Mo - nar - chies that Fe - mi - nine, Of fa - mous
 Their la - bour's rest - lesse to main - taine their state: Their Hex - a -

That their owne li - mits can - not them suf - fice; To seeke new
 Vouch - safe with Trine As - pect re - ply to make, To sweet - est

8

om 1634

A - ma - zons ex - cels the rest, That on this ear - thie Sphaere have e - ver bin,
 go - ni - a no Be - za - lell for cu - rious Art, may passe or im - i - tate,

ci - ties for new Ha - bi - ta - tion, They send a - broad their num' - rous Co - lo - nies:
 Tre - ble tu - ning swee - ter Base: Hir mourne - full suit a joy - full end doth take:

verse 2?

13

Whose lit - tle hearts in wea - ker sex (so great in field) No pow - ers
 One Sov' - raign, and but one, com - mands - - - - - this peo - ple loyall, the great Mar -

An - ti - o - pe the prime Prince gone, O - ri - thya soone Of hir Queene -
 And then, when fit time they es - py, Some thou - sands strong This Ar - mie

18 om 1634

of the might-iest Males can make to yeeld: They li - ving aye, most so - ber
pesewith plen - ty blest of is - sue royall: An - ti - o - pe, and O - ri -
mo - ther, ma - king mone, Begs the like boone: That with hir traine hir for - tune
roy - all gal - lant - ly Doth march a - long. Harke, harke, methinkes I heare in

23 Fine

and most chaste, Their paine-got goods in plea - sure scorne to wast.
thy - ia faire, With o - ther Prin - ces hir In - fan - tas are.

she may seeke: And this she sings in mea - sures mourn - full sweete.
Notes of choice, This fair - est La - dies swee - test mourn - full voice.

27 new ♩ = old ♩

Meane

30

34

37

L'istesso tempo

41

5. But all this while shee doth chant it a - lone, Most hum - bly
 6. Hir Mo - thers si - lence makes her much to doubt, Hir Grace un -

7. Im - port' - nate O - ri - thy - ia now hath woon Hir sterne Queene -
 8. These La - dies Mu - si - call Con - sort as - sures. The Prince his
 9. Where tread - ing the Hey, right nim - bly theyprance, Thus wait - ing
 Or 'tread-ing the Hey'

44

beg - ging in hir Do - rik straines, Of hir deare Liege leave to be
 to her wil this Grace de - nie: But stil hir suit shee doth hold

Mo - thers gránt to hír de - sire: For Joy, hir Sis - ters all as
 much - de - si - red Sov' - raign - tie: The vul - gar when oc - ca - s'on
 their Prince, in and out they trace: Who coom, these Maids the Mo - rice

47

gone, But com - fort none she yet ob - taines.
 out, In hope at last to moove pit - tie.

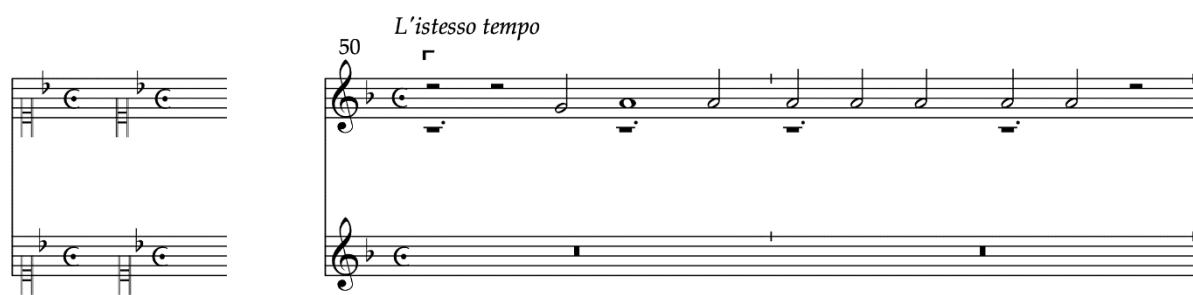
one With cheere - full tones fill up the Quire.
 serves, (this watch - woord past) a - broad dooe hie.
 dance, A - long un - to their rest - ing place.

After verse 6,
continue to bar 50

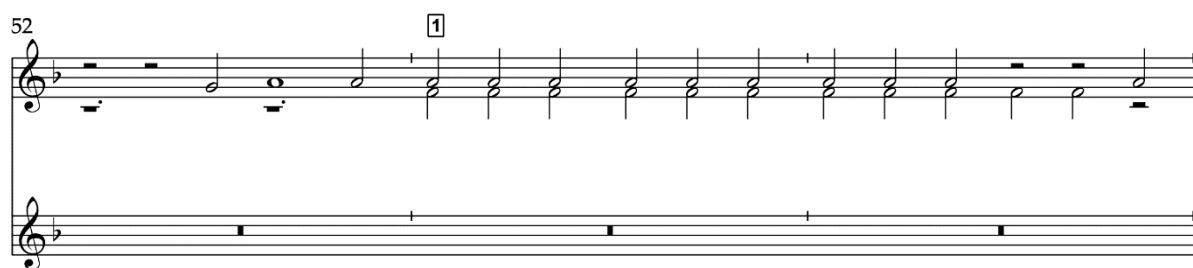
After verse 9,
DA CAPO Verse 1

Before verse 7: Sing this Ditti to the second Tune; repeating the two last strains of the last Staf: and then end with the first verse of the first Song; repeating the two last strains therof. This implies *dal segno* repeats of the second halves of verses 9 and 1 (*da capo*) only.

50 *L'istesso tempo*



52 1



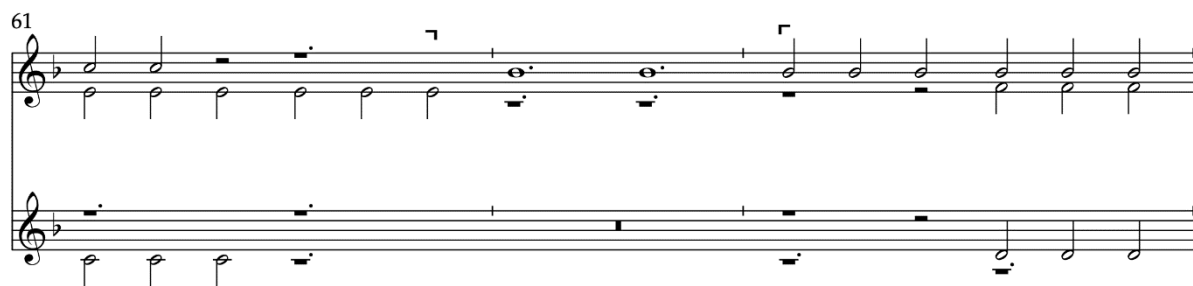
55 2



58 3



61



64

64 65 66

67

67 68 69

62

70

70 71 72

4

73

73 74 75

76

76 77

DAL SEGNO % *Return to verse 7*

Editions

- 1623 Charles Butler, *The Feminine Monarchie or the History of Bees* (London: John Haviland for Roger Jackson, 1623; RSTC 4193), sigs. [K4]v, L[1]r-v, L2r
- 1634 Charles Butler, *The feminin^e monarchi^e, or the histori of bee^s* (Oxford: William Turner for the author, 1634; RSTC 4194), pp. 78-81 (sigs. L3v, [L4]r-v, M[1]r). This includes phonetic spelling of text underlay and revisions by Butler to syllabification of text underlay, punctuation, deletion of semibreve rests between lines and one instance of part-writing

Copies consulted

- 1623 **Cambridge**, University Library, Keynes S.1.29; **Cambridge**, University Library, Syn.7.62.248; **Cornell** University Library (via IMSLP); **London**, British Library, C.118.bb.1(2); **London**, British Library, Cup.405.i.21.3; **Paris**, Bibliothèque Nationale, Tolbiac S3409.Wisconsin/Hathi Trust;
- 1634 **Cambridge**, University Library (via EEBO); **London**, Wellcome Library (via IMSLP); John Waterer collection (via Sotheby's catalogue).

Other copies

- 1623 **Canterbury** Cathedral Library; National Library of Scotland (MRB.107); **Chicago**, Northwestern University (595.79 B97); **Chicago**, Newberry Library (Case O 97 .128); **Göttingen**, Niedersächsische Staats- und Universitätsbibliothek (8DGZool.VI,9512); New Zealand: Rothamsted Experimental Station, **Harpenden**; **British Library** (Cup.405.i.21/3 or C.118.bb.1(2).); **Lansing**, Library of Michigan (xx SF 525 .B8 1623); **London**, University College Library: Strong Room OGDEN A 522; **London** University Library ([D.-L.L.] Y10 [Butler]); **London**, Natural History Museum (ENTOMOLOGY SPECIAL BOOKS O B.29.); **Madison**, University of Wisconsin-Madison, Memorial Library (Thordarson T474); **New Haven**, Beinecke (Sth12 350); **Oxford**, Bodleian Library (Vet. A2 e.22 (5) and Vet.A2e.22(8).); **Oxford**, Merton College, Oxford (75.F.5(6).); **Oxford**, St John's College (HB4/3.a.5.22); **Providence**, John Carter Brown Library; **San Marino**, Huntington Library (357272); **Washington DC**, Folger Shakespeare (STC 4193, Copy 1 and 4193 Copy 2); **Wellington**, Alexander Turnbull Library, National Library of New Zealand (REng.BUTLER.Femi.1623); **Williamstown** College Library.
- 1634 46 copies are listed on USTC

Tempo relationships: in imperfect time throughout, with minor prolation in verses 1-4 and major prolation thereafter. Butler's notation of the void semibreves in bar 32 confirms that one imperfect semibreve has the same temporal duration as one full black perfect semibreve. This conforms with Butler's own precept: 'The principal *Time*-note is the *Semibrief*: by whose Time, the time of all Notes is known'(Charles Butler, *The Principles of Musik in Singing and Setting* (London: John Haviland for the author, 1636; RSTC 4196), p. 24).

Abbreviations:

- Part-names: M = Meane/Medius, C = Contratenor, T = Tenor, B = Bassus.
- Note values: *b* = brevis/breve, *L* = longa/long, *m* = minima/minim, *s* = semibrevis/semibreve.
- Mensuration signs: cut-C sig = imperfect time with minor prolation (simple duple time), C-dot sig = imperfect time with major prolation (compound duple time).
- Other: col = coloured, dot = dotted

Critical Notes

2 C 1623 no slur DE

2, verse 3, Butler does not clearly syllabify 'increased is this prudent nation'; other solutions include subdividing the second minim of b. 2 ('is this') and then assigning trisyllabic 'na-ti-on' to the three chords of b. 3. Unfortunately, the phonetic typesetting in 1634 fails to elucidate this.

7 all voices 1623 s-rest before first note

7-9, verse 2, all voices 1623 'Hexa-gonia no Be-za-leell', placement suggesting ligation of '-nia' and division of 'leell' (but 'leell' rhymes with 'weale')

8, verse 3, Butler does not clearly syllabify 'for new Habitation'; other solutions include subdividing the third and fourth chords of b. 8 ('for new / Ha-bi') and assigning '-ta-ti-on' to b. 9.

11 T 1623 1634 mD recte mB?

13 all voices 1623 s-rest before first note

14 C 1634 flat to E

20 all voices 1623 'roy-all' for 'royall' (but rhymes with 'loyall', one syllable); all voices 1623 s-rest after bar line

22-23 C 1623 mF mD mF mF mE sF for mF mD mD mC mC sF

24 all voices 1623 s-rest before first note

26 all voices 1623 'Infantaes' for 'Infantas'

27 M 1623 C-dot sig; C T B 1623 C1 clef, C-dot sig, 7 L-rests

31 M 1634 second dot-s-rest omitted

32 M 1623 cut-C sig, sA sA both void

33 M 1623 C-dot sig?

40 M 1623 col bA undotted

41 B 1634 cut-C sig for C-dot sig

47 M 1634 dot omitted to dot-mA

49 M 1634 final note printed as E in Wellcome copy (only)

50 C 1623 1 L-rest, 1 b-rest; T 1623 4 L-rests, 1 b-rest; B 1623 3 L-rests, 1 b-rest

52 M 1623 '1' above ¹A

57 M 1623 '2' above ¹B

59 M 1623 '3' above ¹C

61 C 1623 ⁵mE misprinted by rotation of character to mB, manually corrected in all inspected copies.

62 M 1623 cut-C sig, void sB sB; C T B 1 col b-rest (no change of sig)

67 B 1623 '62' above ⁵D, meaning unclear

70 T 1623 '4' above ¹C

78 all voices 1634 'Sing this Ditti to the second Tune; repeating the two last strains of the last Staf: and then end with the first verse of the first Song; repeating the two last strains therof'